

Point Breeze

From Black Working-Class Roots to White-Collar Growth

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Table of Contents

01 | Executive Summary 03

02 | Introduction to Point Breeze 04

Geographic Context & Religious Institutions

03 | Historical Timeline 06

04 | Demographics 08

Changes in Age Groups, Racial Composition, Educational Attainment & In-migration

05 | Housing 13

Shifting Household Patterns, Increasing Housing Costs & Aging Homes

06 | Economy & Employment 16

Changes in Income, Basic Industries & Employment Type

07 | Challenges & Opportunities 20

References 23

06 Economy

Growth of the proportion of higher-earning households

Between 2013 and 2023, we observe that there is an increase in the number of high-earning households. In 2013, less than 1% of households earned $200,000 or more per year; however, in 2023, this share increases to over 11% - an increase of 10 percentage points. If this change was merely due to inflation, we would observe roughly the same distribution shape just shifted to the right, yet the shape of the distribution of income suggests that the neighborhood has become wealthier overall, given its concentrated towards the right-end (Figure 11).

The range of household median incomes has widened between 2013 and 2023. In 2013, household median income in Point Breeze ranged from $24,080-$36,724, expanding to $55,288-$116,354 in 2023. Specifically, in the northwestern corner of Point Breeze adjacent to Graduate Hospital, census tracts 20 and 21 reported the highest median incomes in 2023, at $106,420 and $116,354 respectively. However, in the southeastern corner of Point Breeze, census tract 30.01 reported the lowest median income of $55,288.

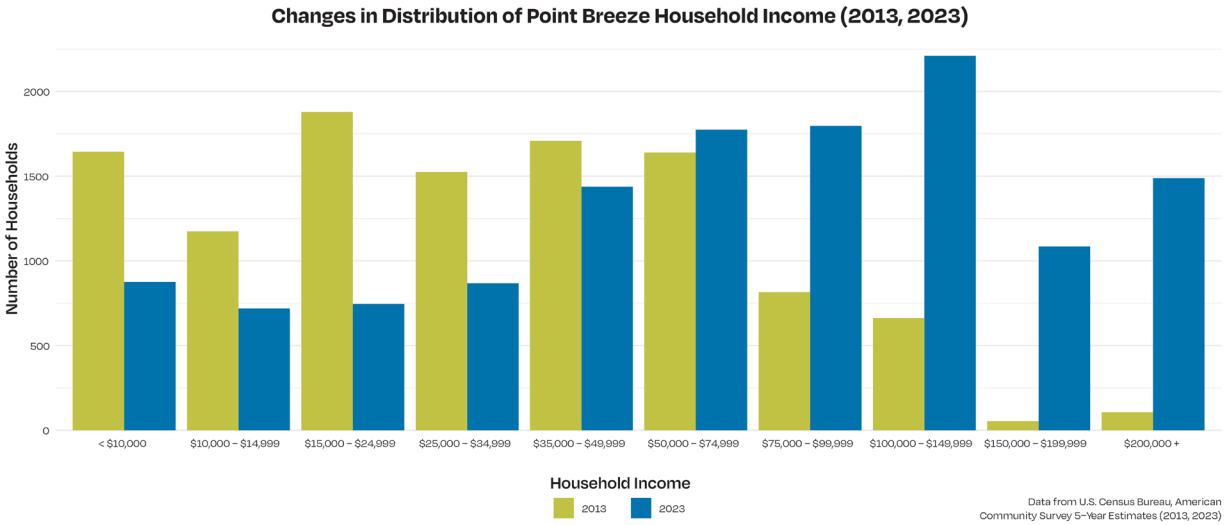


Figure 11: Changes in Distribution of Point Breeze Household Income (2013, 2023)



Image 4 : Point Breeze Alleyway, Source: Alexa Halim

Black households earn less than the average Point Breeze residents

Black household income is lower than the household income of the rest of the neighborhood, indicative of household income disparities by race. As mentioned previously, in 2023, the median household income range in Point Breeze was $55,288-$116,354. However, the median household income range for Black households in Point Breeze was $29,766-$65,038, indicating a clear disparity in the median income of Black households compared to all households. The distribution of Black median household income reveals that there are less high-earning Black households relative to the total household income distribution in Point Breeze (Figure 12).

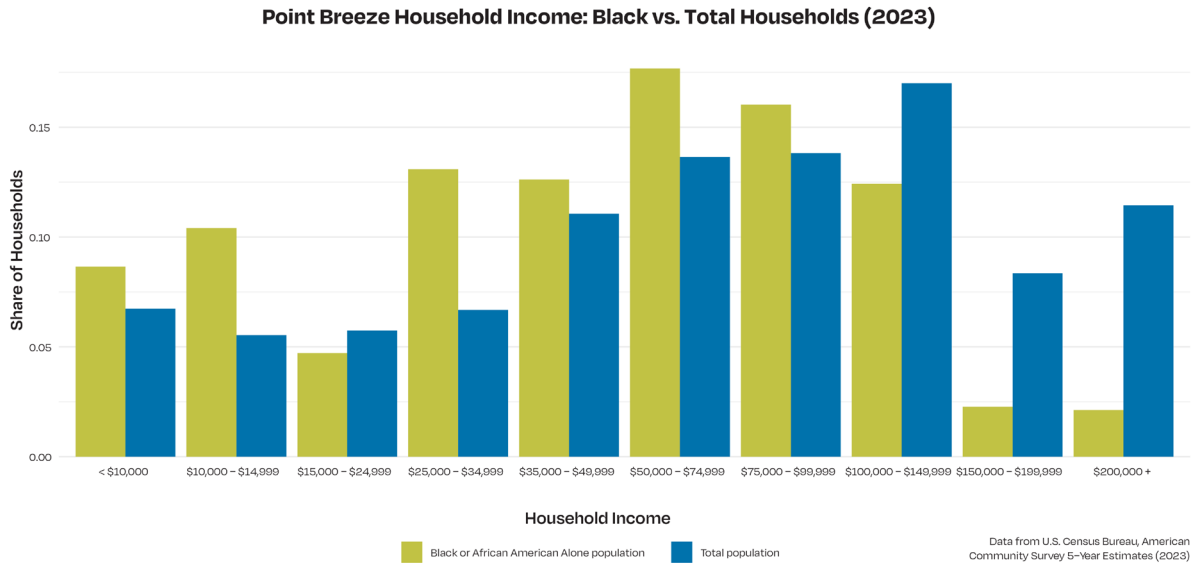


Figure 12: Point Breeze Household Income: Black vs. Total Households (2023)

Mix of blue-collar and white-collar basic industries

In 2013, the main basic industries of Point Breeze (based on a location quotient threshold of >= 1) were construction, manufacturing, healthcare, waste management, real estate and leasing, and wholesale trade, indicating a lean towards more blue-collar industries (Figure 13). By 2022, several of these industries remained basic industries, like construction and manufacturing, even though their overall prominence diminished. Conversely, real estate strengthened its status as a basic industry, and professional services emerged as a new basic industry, suggesting a mix of both blue-collar and white-collar basic industries in Point Breeze.

More jobs being created as driven by basic industries

In 2013, every additional basic industry job supported about 1.22 total jobs in Point Breeze, increasing to 1.32 total jobs in 2022. This suggests that Point Breeze is undergoing job growth, creating more employment opportunities.

Unlike Point Breeze, Philadelphia's basic industries are more concentrated towards white-collar industries, including educational services, healthcare, professional/scientific/technical services, art and entertainment, and management of companies and enterprises. In 2013, for these predominantly white-collar industries, every additional basic industry job supported about 1.58 total jobs in Philadelphia, increasing to 1.75 total jobs in 2022. Therefore, although both Philadelphia and Point Breeze are experiencing job growth as driven by basic industries, Philadelphia is experiencing job growth at a greater rate.

Both Philadelphia and Point Breeze demonstrate an increased reliance on basic industries to support overall job growth, indicating that strong industries will continue to grow, but also that both areas are more vulnerable upon the collapse of these industries.

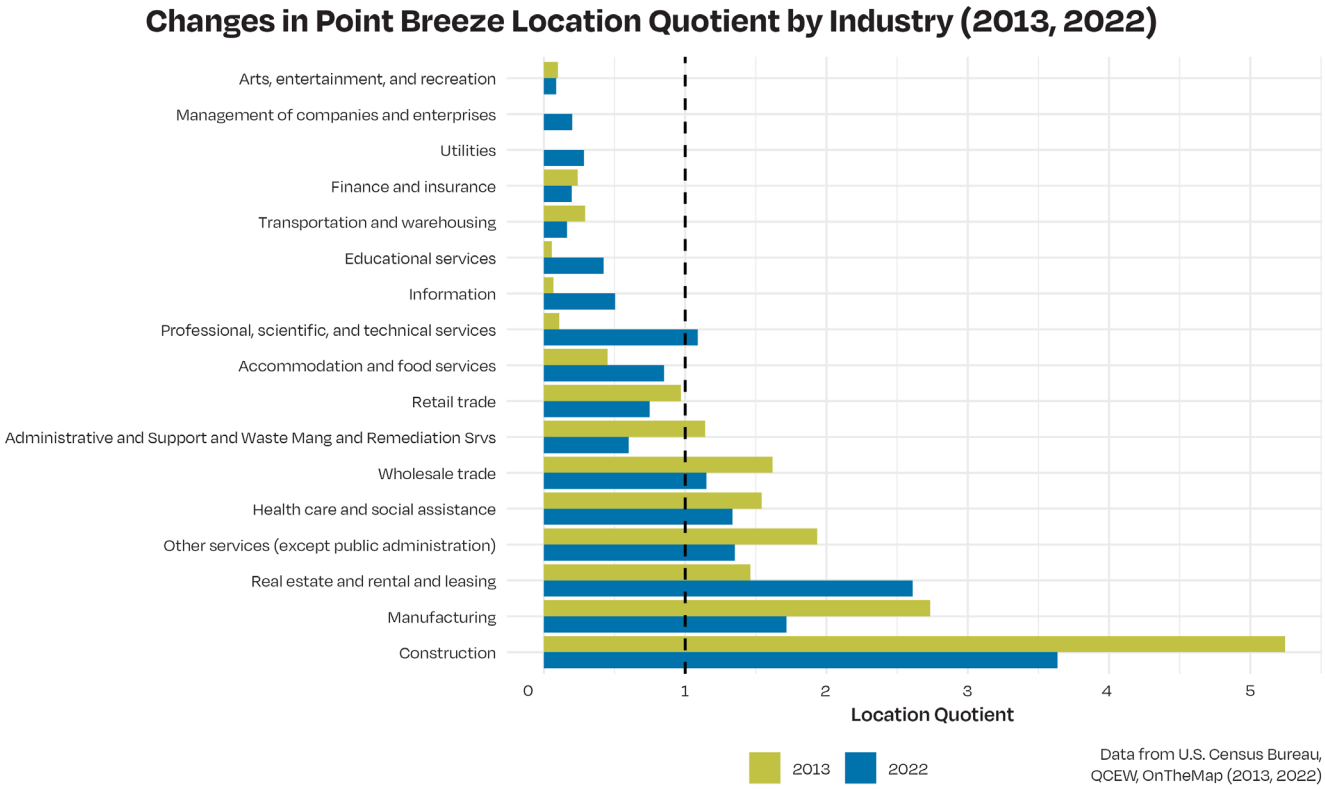


Figure 13: Changes in Point Breeze Location Quatient by Industry (2013, 2022)

Changing demographic of high-earning, remote workers

Point Breeze has a higher share of remote workers compared to the rest of Philadelphia. In 2023, about 29% of workers in Point Breeze worked from home—almost double the share of Philadelphians that work from home.

In addition, remote workers have a higher median range of earnings relative to the rest of the Point Breeze population. In 2023, the median range of earnings in the past 12 months for remote workers lies between $54,444 - $95,859, while the median range of earnings in the past 12 months across all means of transportation lies between $43,429 - $76,607.

Black workers are also less represented in the remote worker population. As of 2023, 15.8% of the Black working population works from home, whereas 34.7% of the White working population works from home. This suggests that the large share of remote working population is more driven by White remote workers as opposed to Black remote workers.

2030 Employment Projection:

Greatest projected increase in the absolute number of healthcare, professional, and food service industries in Point Breeze

In 2030, we project that there will be an additional 1,116 total jobs for all sectors—a total of 3,806 total jobs in Point Breeze. The industries that are projected to experience the largest increases in terms of absolute job growth include: healthcare (412 jobs), professional/scientific/technical services (244 jobs), and food services (138 jobs). Conversely, industries that are projected to experience stagnating growth or decline include: manufacturing (-9 jobs), administrative support and waste management services (-2 jobs), and transportation and warehousing (1 job) (Figure 14). This indicates that Point Breeze will continue to have an increasing share of white-collar basic industries as opposed to blue-collar basic industries.

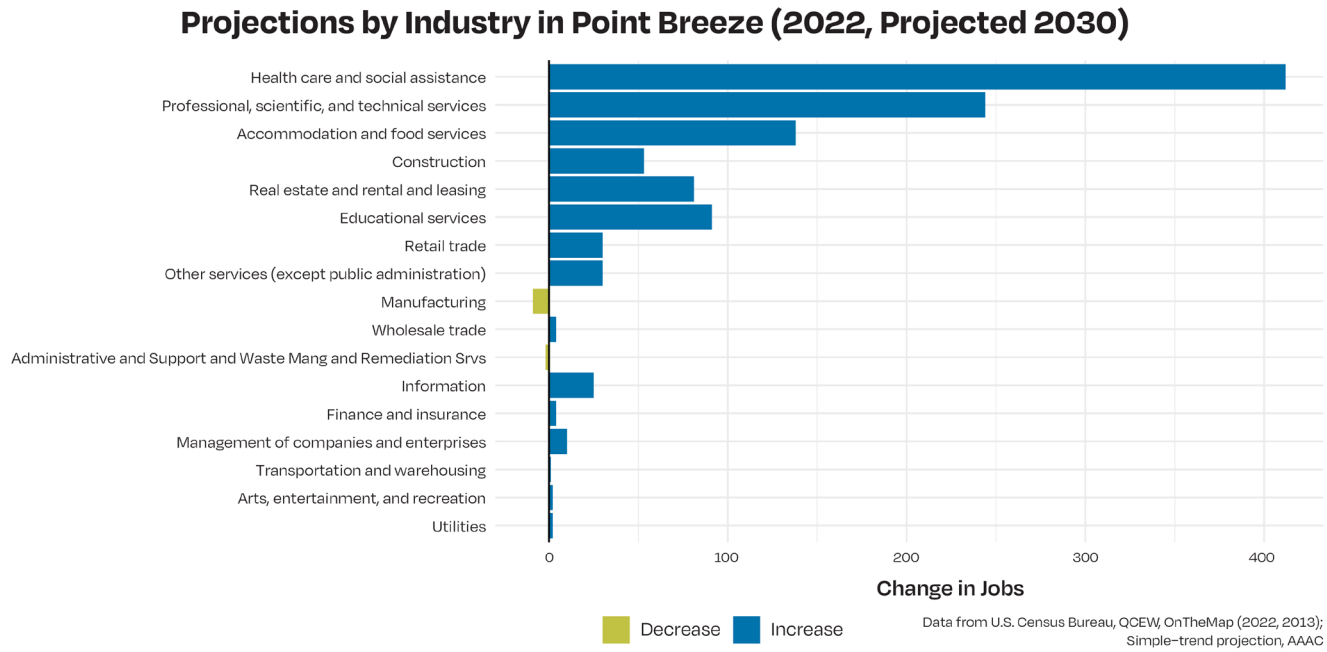


Figure 14: Projections by Industry in Point Breeze (2022, Projected 2030)

07 Challenges & Opportunities

Challenges

01 Gentrification and loss of the historic Black community

Higher-income white households are moving in while the Black population declines, and cases like no longer operating African-American historical religious sites signal ongoing displacement pressure (Figure 2).

02 Rising rent burden for low-income renters

Rents have increased faster than some residents' incomes, leaving many renters paying 30% or more of their income for housing.

03 Fewer opportunities for blue-collar workers

Employment is moving away from manufacturing, construction, and similar blue-collar sectors, reducing accessible jobs for low-income and less-educated workers.

04 Income polarization and a thin middle class

The gap between high-income professionals and low-income residents is widening, with fewer middle-income households to anchor long-term social and economic stability.

05 "Single life-stage" age structure

The population is increasingly dominated by people in their 20s–40s, while children and seniors make up a smaller share, pushing Point Breeze toward a young-adult-only community.

Oppotunities

01 Reviving and Adapting Churches

A key opportunity lies in the prevalence of religious institutions in Point Breeze. As the community changes with the influx of new residents, it is important to preserve and strengthen the physical spaces where the community is cultivated. For churches and other religious spaces that are on the brink of collapse, financial assistance or grant programs would allow them to continue running and providing a space for long-time residents. Vacant churches and buildings, on the other hand, provide an opportunity to address increasing housing costs. Adaptive reuse of these buildings into affordable housing can mitigate the out-migration of residents.

02 Workforce Development

Additionally, investing in training programs that provide residents with the option to transition to white-collar basic industries like healthcare and professional/technical/professional services would support residents amidst the changing economy. This will provide residents with flexible options to return to school and gain new credentials as growing industries require more educational expertise.

03 Small Business Assistance

To support more Black-owned small businesses, grants, low-interest loans, and technical assistance programs should be created to retain and grow Black-owned businesses. Furthermore, a city-supported coalition should be established that connects local business-owners to resources, mentorship, and procurement opportunities.

04 Homeowner Home Repair Programming

Implementing homeowner home repair programs would help to bolster the resilience of Black homeowners against rising housing costs and displacement. As the housing stock in Point Breeze continues to age, homeowners may increasingly face necessary repairs to their homes. This would put a greater burden on residents' monthly housing costs, thereby putting them at a higher risk of being displaced. In the case of Black homeowners without a mortgage, home repair programs would further insulate these residents from increasing housing costs and lessen the vulnerability of already cost-burdened Black homeowners. These programs would create an opportunity to hire qualified lower-income residents to perform the repairs, maintaining blue-collar basic industries in the area.



Image 5 : Wharton Square Park, Source: Alexa Halim

05 Affordable Housing Development

As housing costs and values continue to rise and higher income, White households gain a larger foothold in a historically Black neighborhood; it is imperative to consider further development of affordable housing. Among other avenues, one potential option to support this goal lies in the Philadelphia Accelerator Fund which "provides flexible financing for affordable housing and works to increase access to capital for historically disadvantaged groups, with a focus on Black and Brown developers." [8]

06 Community Building

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